First, we assume you're familiar with Ruby. You don't need to be an expert. We stick to the basics of classes, methods, and blocks for the most part. We will be directing you to install several Ruby gems, so it'll be useful to be familiar with that process as well. If you're new to Ruby, we recommend you first learn the language a bit using resources like Zed Shaw's *Learn Ruby the Hard Way* eBook or the Ruby tutorials at exercism.io.[3,4]

Although you'll be building a web service over the course of several chapters, we don't assume that you're already a web developer. Lots of folks use RSpec to test command-line apps, GUI apps, and so on. We'll explain a few web development concepts as they come up during the discussion.

When we have content that's meant for a specific audience—such as people coming from an older version of RSpec or folks who are new to web development—we'll put that content in a sidebar.

A Note on Versions

The libraries we're using in this book, both the ones from the RSpec framework and other dependencies like Sinatra and Sequel, are designed to be backward-compatible across minor version upgrades. The code examples you see here should work just fine in future versions of these libraries—at least until their next *major* versions.

While we've tested this code on multiple Ruby versions as far back as Ruby 2.2, you'll have the best experience if you follow along with the exact same versions we call out in the text: Ruby 2.4, RSpec 3.6, and so on. With the same versions we use, you should get output that closely mirrors what we show in the book.

Online Resources

This book has a website.[5] There, you'll find links to source code, discussion forums, and errata. We've also set up GitHub repositories containing all the examples in the book, plus a version of the project you'll build in *Building an App With RSpec 3*.[6]

3. https://learnrubythehardway.org
4. http://exercism.io/languages/ruby/about
5. https://pragprog.com/book/rspec3/effective-testing-with-rspec-3
6. https://github.com/rspec-3-book